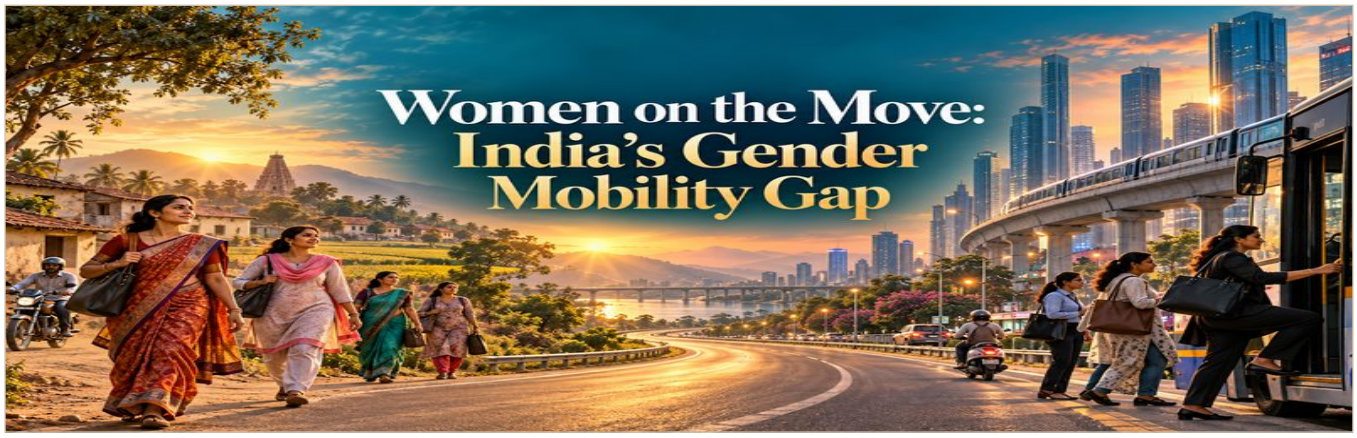


Akella Raghavendra Sir
Founder & Chief Mentor

[GS PAPER I – SOCIETY • GS PAPER II - GOVERNANCE AND SOCIAL JUSTICE • GS PAPER III - ECONOMY AND INFRASTRUCTURE]
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Women on the Move: India's Gender Mobility Gap



India's Household Travel Survey reveals gender gaps in work commutes, transport choices and travel costs across rural and urban areas. The article examines how affordability, safety and connectivity shape women's mobility and access to employment.

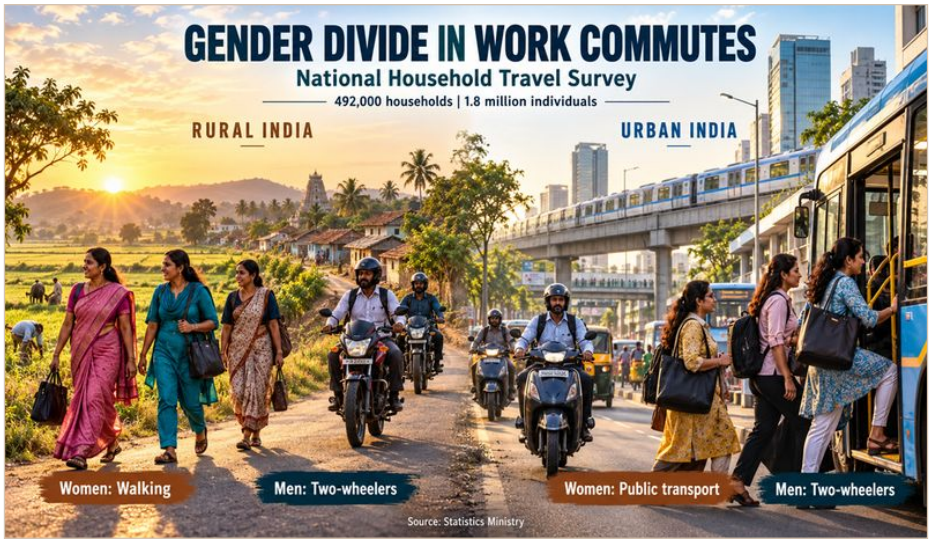
Women on the Move: India's Gender Mobility Gap

Syllabus areas:

GS Paper I – Society

GS Paper II - Governance and Social Justice

GS Paper III - Economy and Infrastructure



India's first **National Household Travel Survey**, conducted by the Statistics Ministry and covering **492,000 households and 1.8 million individuals**, reveals a gender divide in travel to work. Working women are more likely to **walk to their workplaces in rural areas** and **use public transport in urban areas**, while working men rely heavily on **two-wheelers in both rural and urban areas**.

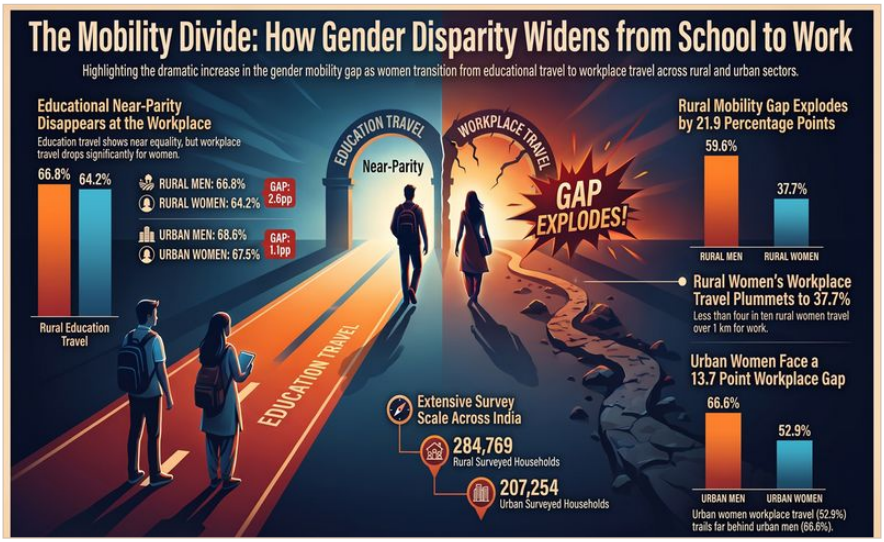
The National Household Travel Survey collects data on household travel patterns, commuting modes, and mobility

characteristics. It helps analyse transport accessibility, gender disparities, travel behaviour, and urban mobility for evidence-based policymaking.

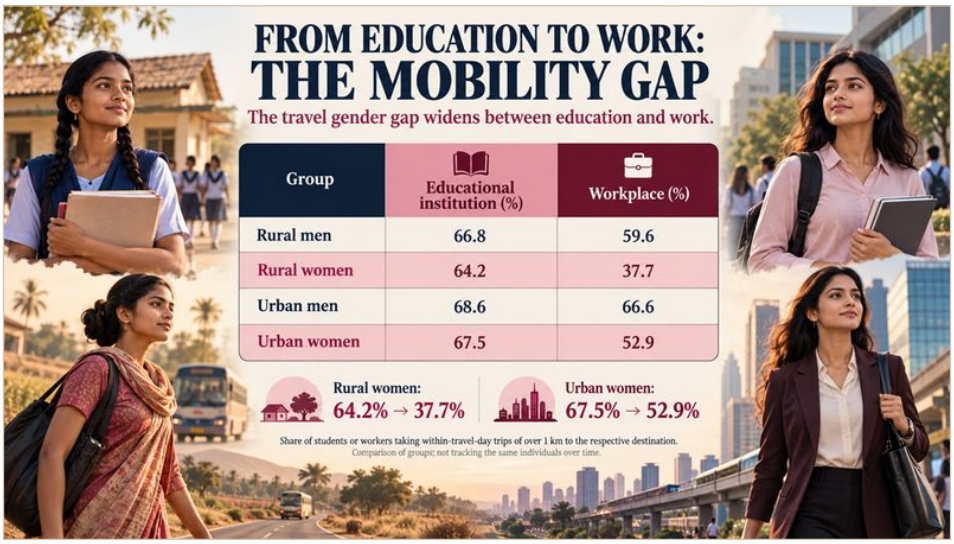


Gender Gap in Mobility: From Education to Employment

Traditional gender roles often restrict women's movement to their homes and nearby areas, limiting access to opportunities and interaction with the wider world. While travel for education shows near parity between men and women, a substantial gender gap emerges in travel to work.



The **Household Travel Survey**, shows the following shares of students or workers undertaking trips of more than one kilometre within a travel day:

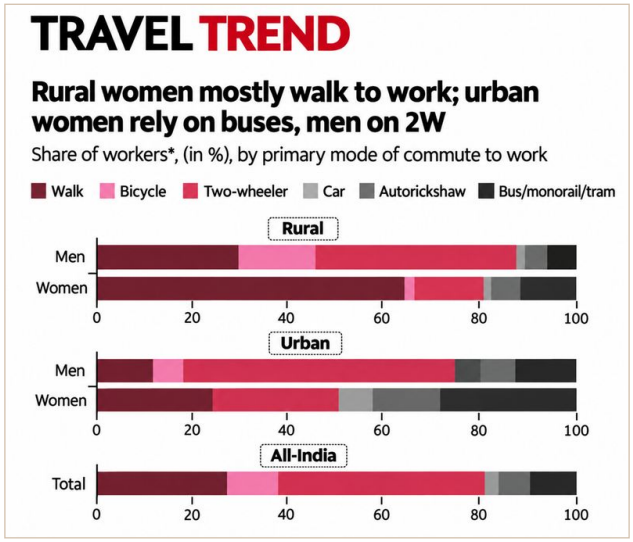


Women's workplace travel is markedly lower than their educational travel, particularly in rural areas. The **gender gap widens from 2.6 percentage points for education to 21.9 percentage points for work in rural areas**, and from **1.1 to 13.7 percentage points in urban areas**. These patterns highlight constraints on women's mobility associated with employment.

The survey covered **284,769 rural households and 207,254 urban households**. Educational travel figures refer to students aged **six years and above**, while workplace travel figures refer to workers aged **15 years and above**. The comparison concerns different groups rather than tracking the same individuals from education into employment.

Gender and Regional Differences in Commuting Patterns in India

Commuting patterns in India reflect significant differences based on gender and rural–urban geography, influencing women's mobility and access to employment opportunities.



Group	Main statistical pattern
Rural men	Two-wheelers account for the largest share, followed by walking.
Rural women	Walking accounts for the largest share, followed by two-wheelers.
Urban men	Two-wheelers clearly dominate work commutes.
Urban women	Bus/monorail/tram accounts for the largest share, followed closely by two-wheelers.
All-India total	Two-wheelers account for the largest share, followed by walking.

- Rural women: Walking is the predominant mode of commuting to work, with more than two-thirds of working women who travel to work walking to their workplaces. This indicates that their work-related mobility is often constrained by

distance and access to transport.

- Rural men: Although walking remains common, men also use two-wheelers and bicycles, reflecting greater diversity in commuting modes.

- Urban women: Their commuting patterns are more diverse. While a significant proportion walk or use two-wheelers, buses and other forms of public transport, including autorickshaws, play an important role.

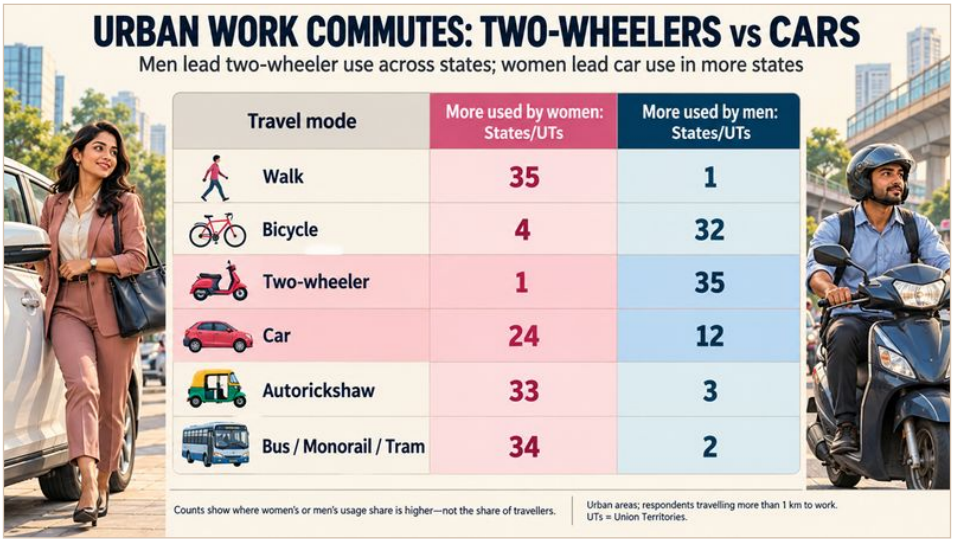


- Urban men: Two-wheelers are a major mode of commuting, alongside walking and other transport options.

Two Wheeler vs CAR

Urban commuting patterns reveal significant gender-based differences in transport choices, shaped by accessibility, affordability, personal safety and socio-economic factors.

- Two-wheelers and bicycles: Urban men rely more heavily on two-wheelers and bicycles than women across most states and Union Territories, reflecting differences in mobility preferences and access to transport.



- Walking: Walking is more prevalent among women than men across states and Union Territories, indicating the importance of proximity between residences and workplaces.

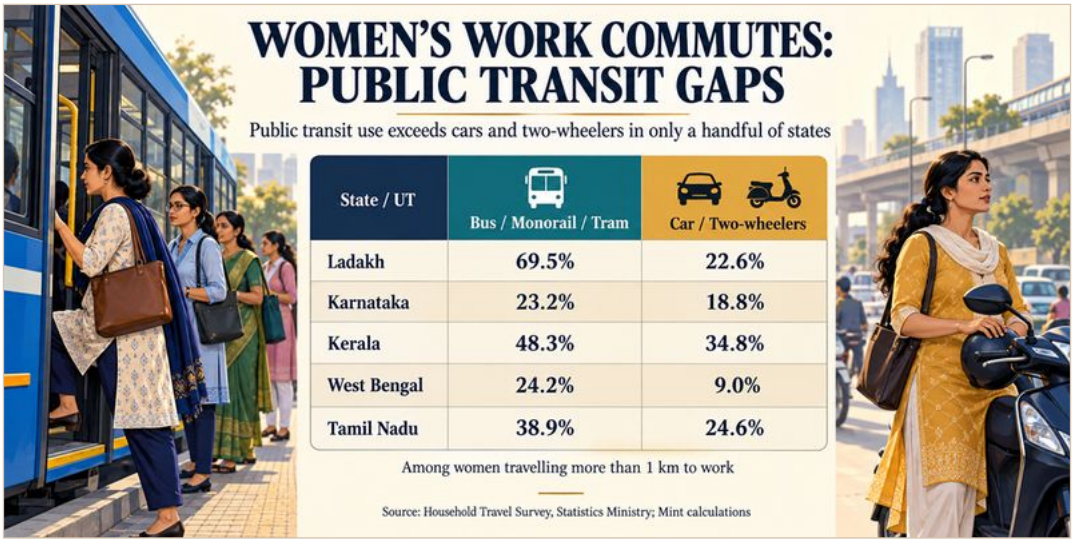
- Car usage: Women rely on cars more than men in a larger number of states and Union Territories. Despite their higher cost compared with two-wheelers, cars may offer greater comfort, privacy and perceived safety.



- Public transport: Buses, autorickshaws and other forms of public transport constitute important commuting options for women, highlighting their role in facilitating access to employment.

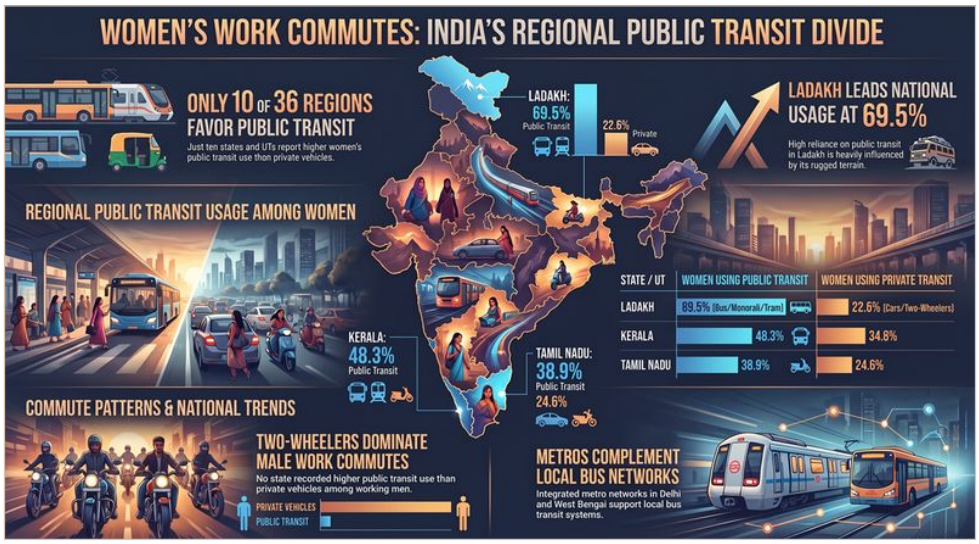
Women's Work Commutes: Regional Gaps in Public Transport Use

Public transport use among women travelling to work varies considerably across India. According to the Household Travel Survey of the Ministry of Statistics, with calculations by *Mint*, only **10 of the 36 states and Union Territories** recorded higher use of buses, monorails and trams among women than cars and two-wheelers combined. The findings cover respondents travelling **more than one kilometre to work**.



Women's public transport use is highest in **Ladakh**, which the report suggests may be linked to its rugged terrain. Southern states show relatively strong public transport usage among women. In **West Bengal and Delhi**, metro networks also complement bus services.

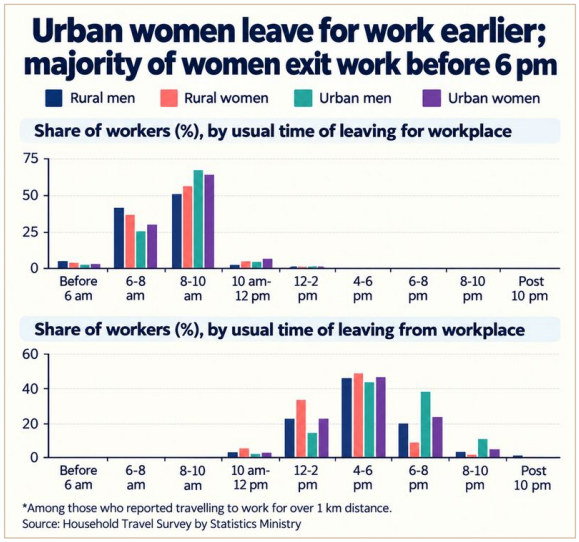
Among men, **two-wheelers dominate work commutes**. No state recorded higher use of the public transit modes considered than cars and two-wheelers combined.



These regional differences underline the importance of **accessible, affordable and safe public transport** for women's mobility and access to employment. Better connectivity, reliable services and integration of buses with metro networks can support more inclusive transport systems.

Women's Work Travel: Gender Differences and Safety Concerns

Women's commuting patterns reflect differences in work schedules and mobility constraints, including safety concerns. The **Household Travel Survey**, conducted by the Ministry of Statistics, shows that women generally leave for work and depart from workplaces earlier than men. These findings cover workers travelling **more than one kilometre to work**.



The largest share of workers across rural and urban groups leaves for work between **8 am and 10 am**. However, a greater proportion of urban women than urban men departs between **6 am and 8 am**.

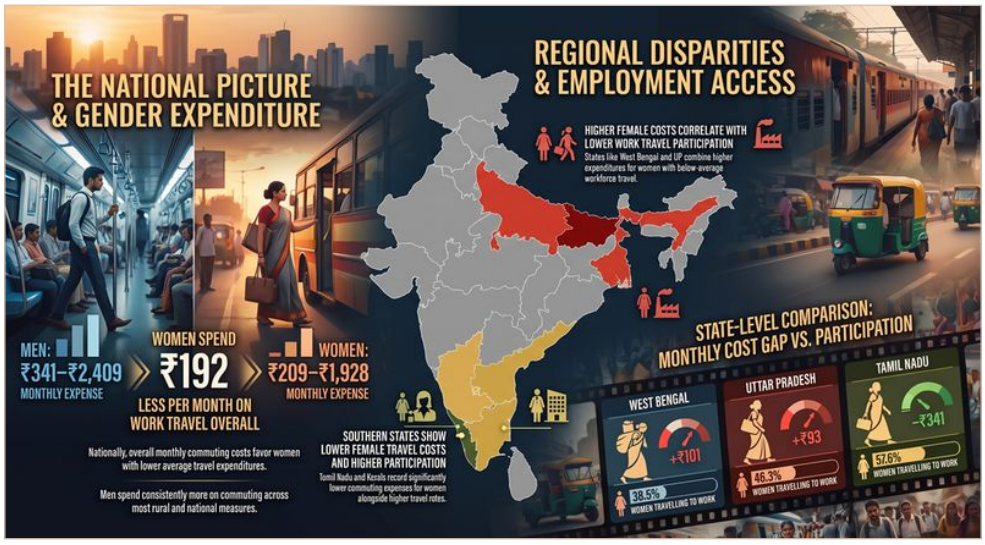


Departure times from workplaces also reveal gender differences. A substantial share of rural women leaves between **12 noon and 2 pm**, while most urban women leave **before 6 pm**. Urban men have the highest proportion leaving workplaces after **6 pm**, including during the **8–10 pm** period.

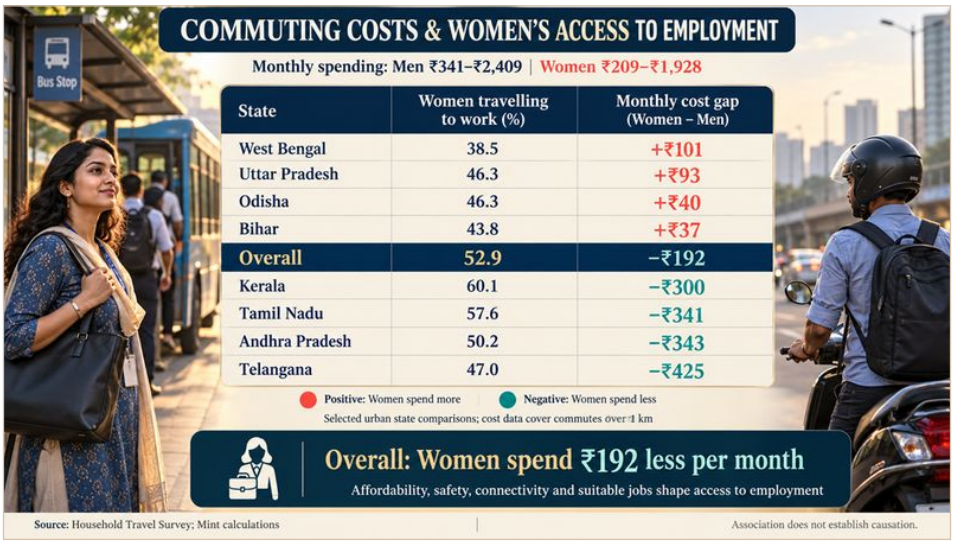
These patterns raise questions about how safety concerns, employment conditions and household responsibilities influence women's access to work. **The timing data alone does not establish safety as the cause**, but it highlights the need for safe evening transport, better street lighting, reliable last-mile connectivity and secure public spaces to support women's employment opportunities.

Commuting Costs and Women's Access to Employment

The cost of travelling to work has a gender dimension, with significant differences across states. According to the **Household Travel Survey**, with calculations by *Mint*, men generally spend more on commuting than women. Reported monthly expenditure ranges from **Rs. 341–Rs. 2,409 for men**, compared with **Rs. 209–Rs. 1,928 for women**.



Although this pattern is consistent across rural areas, women face higher commuting costs than men in the urban areas of some states.



Cost comparisons cover people travelling more than one kilometre to work. Positive figures indicate higher expenditure by women; negative figures indicate lower expenditure.

West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh, Odisha and Bihar combine higher commuting expenditure for women with a below-average share of women travelling to work. In contrast, **Kerala and Tamil Nadu** record lower commuting costs for women relative to men and a higher share of women travelling to work. This relationship is not uniform across all states and does not, by itself, establish causation.

Overall, women spend **Rs. 192 less per month** on work travel than men. The regional differences highlight transport affordability as an important consideration in women's access to employment, alongside safety, connectivity and the availability of suitable jobs.